

Why Graduate School Couldn't Finish the Job

Knowing a skill and being able to use it live are different things.

THE IDEA

A reflection is simple to define and hard to deliver. In a real session you have to notice what matters, choose what to reflect, find natural language, time it, and watch how it lands, all while still tracking the client. School gave you the concept. Fluency is a separate process, and it happens in five distinct stages.

THE FIVE STAGES OF CLINICAL INTEGRATION

KNOW IT I can explain the skill and what it's for.

RECOGNIZE IT I can spot when it's needed, often after the session ends.

ACCESS IT I can remember it in the moment, while the session is happening.

APPLY IT I can actually use it out loud, even if it still feels awkward.

ADAPT IT I can adjust it to fit this particular client, culture, and moment.

WHY PEOPLE PICK THE WRONG FIX

When you don't know which stage you're in, you reach for more information, like another training, another set of scripts. But you could watch twenty videos about silence and still panic when the room goes quiet. That's not a knowledge gap; it's a practice gap, and only repetition and feedback will close it.

ASK YOURSELF

Pick one skill you feel you should be better at. Which of the five stages are you actually in? Then practice the next one, not all five at once.

"I should already be good at this" creates shame. "I understand this and I'm still learning to access it" creates direction.